

► 551–479 BCE

CONFUCIUS

One of the most important early Chinese philosophers, Confucius taught that in order to live good and happy lives, people should respect their neighbours, honour their families, and obey their rulers.

“To study and not think is a waste. To think and not study is dangerous.”

► 469–399 BCE

SOCRATES

One of the greatest Greek thinkers, Socrates devised a way of testing theories that involved asking lots of questions until he arrived at the truth. To him, the most important question of all was: “What makes a good life?”

“I am not an Athenian or a Greek, but a citizen of the world.”

► 427–347 BCE

PLATO

Plato thought that our world is a faulty reflection of a perfect world that exists somewhere else. He founded the world's first university, the Academy, near Athens in Greece.



► 384–322 BCE



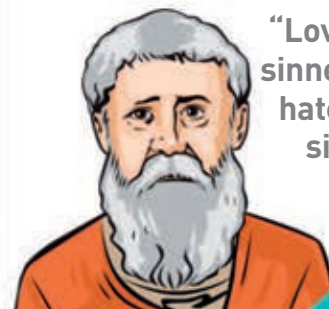
ARISTOTLE

Plato's pupil, Aristotle, is often called the first scientist. He believed that we should base our theories on what we have seen and experienced, rather than what we feel is true.

► 354–430 CE

AUGUSTINE OF HIPPO

Born in North Africa, Augustine was a Christian leader and thinker. He tried to explain why there is so much evil in our world, when God, who created it, is perfectly good.



“Love the sinner and hate the sin.”

◀ 1588–1679

THOMAS HOBBS

An English philosopher who believed that people are basically selfish. A civilized society needs to agree on a set of laws, then appoint a strong leader to make sure everyone obeys those laws.



◀ 1469–1527

NICCOLO MACHIAVELLI

An Italian writer and diplomat. He wrote *The Prince*, a book of advice for politicians. In it, he argues that sometimes it is right for a leader to do terrible things such as lying or even killing, if they are done for the good of his kingdom.

“The first method for estimating the intelligence of a ruler is to look at the men he has around him.”

◀ 1225–74



THOMAS AQUINAS

A noble-born Italian monk, he wanted to prove God's existence through reason. He believed that it is obvious from observing the world that a supremely intelligent being must have created it, and this being must be God.

◀ 1126–98

IBN-RUSHD (AVERROES)

A Muslim philosopher from Cordoba in Spain. He studied Aristotle and Plato and tried to combine their scientific approach with Muslim religious views to create a unified idea of how the world works.



◀ 1098–1179

HILDEGARD OF BINGEN

A German writer, composer, and nun, Hildegard wrote about how to treat physical diseases by “spiritual healing”. From the age of six she saw visions that seemed to be from God, and she wrote about them in many books.



► 1868–1963

W E B DUBOIS

An African-American historian, author, and campaigner, Dubois fiercely opposed the widely held view of the time that white people were a superior race. He believed that all people were equal and deserved equal rights, whatever their ethnicity or gender.



► 1889–1951



LUDWIG WITTGENSTEIN

One of the 20th century's most influential thinkers. He was especially interested in logic, and the connection between language and the world. He taught that we can only talk or write properly about things that exist.

► 1905–80

JEAN PAUL SARTRE

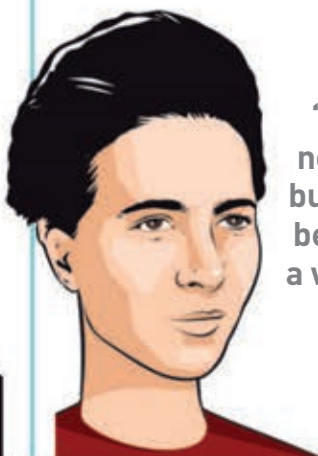
French writer and existentialist thinker. He believed that there is no God, and people have not been invented for any particular purpose: we must choose for ourselves what to do with our lives.



► 1908–86

SIMONE DE BEAUVOIR

French writer who argued that girls are not very different from boys when they are born. But because people treat women differently, they are forced to become submissive and obedient.



“One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman.”

► 1930–2004

JACQUES DERRIDA

French philosopher who devised a way of thinking called “deconstruction”. Language must be pulled apart, or deconstructed, to show how there are no fixed meanings to words. In fact, words get in the way of the search for truth.

“To pretend, I actually do the thing: I have therefore only pretended to pretend.”